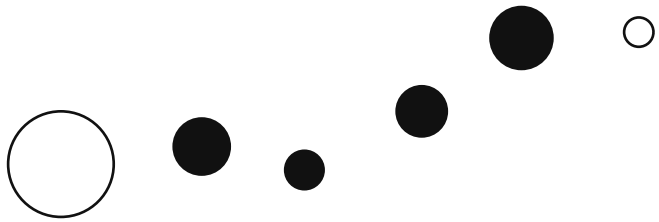
Papier Bleu

No. 1 · January 2015

Papier Bleu



No. 1

JANUARY 2015

PROSE POETRY

PAPIER BLEU

No. 1 · January 2015

A monthly magazine of prose poetry by Columbia undergraduates from CC, Barnard, GS and SEAS.

Where to find it. Free, on the steps of Hamilton Hall, from the first of the month while copies last.

Set in Courier Prime. Printed in New York. 75 copies.

Luca V. (CC ’17) grew up on a farm in Ohio and calls home on Tuesdays.

Sofia W. (Barnard ’17) puts up peaches every August and counts the lids.

Gabriel J. (CC ’15) is a senior from dairy country in Wisconsin.

Ava W. (GS ’15) returned to school after some years away and sets type by hand.

Daniel N. (SEAS ’18) is studying engineering and wrote this piece without the letter L.

Papier Bleu

No. 1

JANUARY 2015

Ten writers on memory and omission

MASTHEAD

Founder & Editor-in-Chief

Kristil Rabideau

Papier Bleu is an independent student magazine. It is not an official publication of Columbia University, and the views expressed belong to the writers.

Contributors are listed on pages 17 and 18.

CONTRIBUTORS

Mira S. (GS ’16) is from Pennsylvania coal country and has kept the pennies.

Samir T. (CC ’16) rides the 1 train from the library and sometimes stays on past his stop.

Clara K. (CC ’16) grew up on the flat part of Kansas and misses the wind.

Ilana M. (CC ’18) has an aunt in California who writes to her on onionskin.

Kofi T. (CC ’18) is from Accra and is learning to like January.

MARAUDE

Daniel N. · SEAS ’18

In Maraude the script has a gap in it,[1] between the K and the M, and everyone grows up speaking around it.[2] The river is brown and fast and stinks of the tanneries upstream, and on the stones of its banks the women beat their sheets white. The grandmothers say the sign is not gone but dark, the way a room is dark with someone dreaming in it.[3]

[1] The young are taught to stop there for one breath, the time it takes to find a stair in the dark with your foot.

[2] Names that once had the sign in them are now said with a pause. At dusk the mothers stand in their doorways and bring their sons and daughters in from the street by crying out the pause.

[3] The grandmothers keep a word for it. They say it into their cupped hands, and it sounds, to anyone near enough to hear, as warm water sounds going into a basin.

[4] This note has no mark in the text above. It stands where the sign stands, and is read with the same pause.

[5] Visitors, who carry the sign in their mouths, are asked to keep quiet in the market. When they forget, the women at the washing stones stop and turn, every one, as if their names had been shouted across the water.

CONTENTS

Tailings 7
Mira S.

Between 28th and 23rd 8
Samir T.

Hays, After Harvest 9
Clara K.

Water Damage 10
Ilana M.

Harmattan 11
Kofi T.

Five Messages 12
Luca V.

Peaches, Put Up 13
Sofia W.

Starting the Tractor in March 14
Gabriel J.

The Lamplighter 15
Ava W.

Maraude 16
Daniel N.

INTERESTED IN SUBMITTING?

Send works no longer than 500 words, in the form of prose poetry. If you are looking for clarity, the best example is Italo Calvino's *Invisible Cities*, or this issue.

Send your work to rabideaukristil@gmail.com.

Please title your email "Papier Bleu Submission" for easy finding.

THE LAMPLIGHTER

Ava W. · GS '15

Evenings the lamplighter comes up our street with his long pole and touches each lamp until it hums. Behind him the vowels go out one by one, and the words stand dark in their windows. My mother's name is the last to go.

vnings th lamplightr coms up our strt with his long pol and touchs ach lamp until it hums. Bhind him th vowls go out on by on, and th words stand dark in thir windows. My mothr's nam is th last to go.

vnngs th lamplghtr cms up ur strt wth hs lng pl and tuchs ach lamp untl t hums. Bhnd hm th vwls g ut n by n, and th wrds stand dark n thr wndws. My mthr's nam s th last t g.

vnngs th lmplghtr cms p r strt wth hs lng pl nd tchs ch lmp ntl t hms. Bhnd hm th vwls g t n by n, nd th wrds stnd drk n thr wndws. My mthr's nm s th lst t g.

Read it aloud. The lamps come back on.

STARTING THE TRACTOR IN MARCH

Gabriel J. · CC ’15

1. Pick a Saturday after the frost has gone out of the ground but not out of the shed. Work your fingers into his gloves. The leather has set in the shape of his grip, and your hand has to argue its way in.

2. Cross the yard past the pear tree, which has been dying since 1998 and still puts out six pears a year. The mud takes your boot to the ankle and lets go with a suck. Don’t look at the kitchen window. Your mother is in it.

3. Knock the wasp nest out of the exhaust with a broom handle. Paper-gray, light as a wedding invitation. Wasps in March are slow enough to flick off your sleeve with one finger.

4. Choke out. Throttle about a third. Nobody can tell you what a third is; he did it by ear. The lever is cold enough to bite your thumb, and the seat holds the cold like a pew. Turn the key. The battery clicks twice and goes quiet.

5. It will not start. Say something to it you wouldn’t say in front of her. Say it in his voice. You have it, it turns out.

6. It will start. On the fourth try it catches and coughs a blue rope of smoke into the cold, and the whole machine shudders like a wet dog, your hands buzzing to the elbow inside his hands, and the field in front of you, black, wet, steaming where the sun gets to it, is exactly as big as last year.

TAILINGS

Mira S. · GS ’16

My uncle Stan was born in Centralia, which is on fire. Has been since 1962, when the borough lit the dump to clean up for Memorial Day and the fire went down into the coal, and it’s down there yet, heyna, working under the hill like a mouse in a wall. Every January he drives me over on 61 to look. Nothing to look at. Streets, no houses. Curbs. A hydrant. Three cement steps going up the bank into the sumac to nobody’s porch. Smoke comes up out of the ground in skinny gray ropes and stinks like a struck match. Snow on everything but these long bare strips where the dirt’s warm as a hood you just parked, and Stan stands in one in his church shoes and says, Kitchen. That’s it. Kitchen. Post office took the ZIP code back in 2002 and he’s still sore about it. On the dash he keeps a coffee can of pennies gone tacky with Pepsi, and in the tape deck the ’87 Fiesta Bowl, the radio call, and he plays it the whole way home, nodding at every down like this time it might come out different.

BETWEEN 28TH AND 23RD

Samir T. · CC ’16

and the whole car smells of wet wool and hot brakes, and the man across from me is eating a rotisserie chicken out of the bag with enormous tenderness, the way you’d feed something that fell asleep in your hands, and a girl is asleep on her sister’s shoulder with one shoe off, the shoe upright on the floor, rocking a little at every curve, and I’m in my mother’s kitchen in Dearborn the Thursday before Eid, trays, trays on the dryer, trays on the radiator, ma’amoul cooling on the piano nobody plays, flour on the cat, my mother rapping the wooden mold on the edge of the counter, crack, and the cookie dropping into her palm with a flower on its back, *yalla*, Samir, the dates, the dates, orange blossom in everything and something always scorching a little, my aunt on the phone saying *khalas, khalas*, it’s fine, it’s fine, and the train goes into the dark between stations and the lights stutter and every one of us looks up at once like a congregation, and the lights come back, and the man has finished the chicken and is folding the bag into a small tight triangle, the way she folds them, and he puts it in his coat, and the doors open on 23rd, and I let them close.

PEACHES, PUT UP

Sofia W. · Barnard ’17

Her recipe card, in pencil, with a thumbprint of syrup in one corner. My notes underneath.

PEACHES. 7 QTS.

Scald 1 min. Cold water. Skins slip right off. If they don’t your peaches are no good.

She cut an X in the bottom of each one first, with a thumbnail that had half the garden under it.

Halve. Pit. Pack cut side DOWN.

Underlined twice. I have tried it the other way. She was right.

Lite syrup to ½ in. Run a knife round to let the air out.

The bubbles let go and climb the glass like held breath.

Lids hand tight. 30 min. Then LEAVE THEM BE.

From the dark hall, one at a time, each lid pulls down with a small tin tink. She counted out loud. So do I.

Feb.: open one.

It smells like August with the windows shut. The syrup comes off the spoon the color of lamplight. I eat it at the sink, juice to the wrist. Her last jar is on the shelf with 8/97 on the lid in her hand. That one stays shut.

FIVE MESSAGES

Luca V. · CC ’17

TUESDAY, 6:12 A.M. Yeah, it’s Dad. Call me. It’s nothing. Call when you’re up.

6:40. Don’t call yet, Mrs. Pruitt’s here with a casserole. Nobody died. It’s a good casserole. Still warm through the foil. I don’t know what she’s doing here.

9:03. *[wind, a screen door]* I’m out at the barn. The gray cat had them in the hay. Six. I counted twice. Blind as thumbs. Your mother says let you sleep, so. That’s the news. Six.

9:05. Forgot. The man came about the well. Best water he’s tested in the county, he says. Said it like he was sorry about it.

11:30. Walked the back forty. Ground’s soft. Smells like a cellar. You could put seed in it tomorrow. Anyhow. Don’t worry about calling.

WEDNESDAY, 5:50 A.M. Yeah, it’s Dad. Call me. It’s nothing.

HAYS, AFTER HARVEST

Clara K. · CC ’16

FOUR O’CLOCK. It is so hot the gate burns you if you hold on. Dad says the custom cutters went north to Nebraska to chase the wheat. That is a dumb thing to chase because wheat stays where you put it, but up there it is still green, so they have to. Grasshoppers hit my legs like somebody is throwing rice. The elevator in town is the tallest thing in the world. Dale says it’s taller than a church, and I said which church, and he said any.

SEVEN. Dale is fourteen and allowed to. He took the bike and his pole down the section road to the stock tank, where the calf drowned in June. He stood up on the pedals the whole way so I could see him a long time.

NINE. Mom said his name one time off the porch. Not loud. Like she didn’t want the dark to hear.

TEN. She is at the end of the drive with no shoes on. The road is still warm. I know because I went out too.

ELEVEN. I am supposed to be asleep. A truck on 183, going to Plainville. Not him. He has a bike.

MIDNIGHT. A bell. Or it’s the tag on a cow’s ear hitting the wire. I’m deciding which.

WATER DAMAGE

Ilana M. · CC ’18

Dear Ruth,

Well. The apricots came all at once this year, [ ] on the porch in colanders, split and sticky, and so many wasps I’ve let them have the back step. Walt isn’t speaking to the Hendersons over the ladder. I told him, a ladder is a ladder, for heaven’s sake. He said that’s [ ]. The creek’s down to puddles you could cross in your church shoes, and that heron stands in the big one on one leg from breakfast to supper and catches nothing.

I found your father’s [ ] behind the freezer, furry with dust, still [ ]. I’ve left it where it is. Some nights I go out and look at it.

It rained Tuesday, ten minutes, just enough to bring up that smell of hot [ ] off the road, and Walt stood in the door holding his hat to his chest like they were playing the anthem, and I thought, well, there he is. There’s the man I [ ].

Write when you can. Bring the good scissors. Don’t tell your mother about the [ ].
Love, Aunt Pearl
P.S. [ ] [ ]

Found in a kitchen drawer in Tulare. A glass of water had stood on it for some time.

HARMATTAN

Kofi T. · CC ’18

In December the harmattan comes down from the Sahara and lays a lid of pale dust over Accra, and the sun goes small and white as a communion wafer you can look straight at. Laundry on the lines in Osu stiffens into boards. Every car wears a fur coat of red-gold powder, and the boys write their names in it with one finger, and by evening the wind has rubbed them out. My grandmother works shea butter into my knuckles, her palms dry as paper, and says the air is thirsty and we are what it drinks. Grit in the bread, grit between the teeth at supper, my lips split and tasting of copper. I am writing this in a dorm in New York in January where the radiator knocks like a man wanting back in, and the snow outside is the cleanest thing I have ever seen, and I keep licking my lips to see if it tastes of anything.